

*The Tree Tells
a Story*



The Tree Tells a Story

A Four-Week Family Advent Devotional

MARTIN J. GALLAGHER

Christmas Tree Devotional

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*"The Bible begins and ends with a tree — and the
whole story of what God has done for us hangs
between them."*

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A Note Before You Begin

Most of us set up a Christmas tree the same way we always have — all at once, in an evening, before December has barely begun. But what if the tree could speak? What if the act of setting it up, lighting it, and decorating it could carry your family through the four weeks of Advent as a living, growing sign of the gospel?

This devotional began as one family's attempt to answer a child's question: "*Why do we put a tree inside our house?*" The answer turned out to run from Genesis to Revelation. From the Tree of Life in the garden to the tree of Calvary, from the darkness before creation to the city where there is no night — God has always been telling His story through trees.

Advent is the four-week season leading up to Christmas Day, beginning on the fourth Sunday before Christmas. Each Sunday your family gathers around the tree and adds one layer — bare branches, then light, then the ornaments of memory and faith, and finally the cross-topper and gifts beneath. The Scriptures open up the meaning of that layer. Fifteen minutes of family worship. A tradition that grows richer every year.

This little book is shaped to follow that rhythm. Each week opens with a short essay to read on the Sunday of family gathering, followed by a four-session study guide for the days that follow. Read at your own pace. Adapt freely. Let the Scriptures do their work.

Before the lights, before the ornaments, before the gifts —
there is just the tree. Just the story of what God has done.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN



Notes on Family Worship

*"As for me and my house,
we will serve the Lord."*

JOSHUA 24:15

Notes on Family Worship

The Simplicity of Family Worship

*F*amily worship does not require a seminary degree, a pipe organ, or a formal liturgy. It requires a Bible, a willing heart, and a few minutes that are intentionally set aside. The early church met in homes, breaking bread "house to house" (Acts 2:46). The Psalms were sung in households and around family tables (Colossians 3:16). And the commandment given to Israel was not to outsource the faith to priests, but to teach it at home: "You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise" (Deuteronomy 6:6-7).

If your family has never practiced regular worship together, Advent is an ideal place to begin. This devotional provides the structure, the Scripture, and the questions. You bring the family and a willingness to sit together regularly through the four weeks.

A Simple Format That Works

Read each session's passages aloud. Sit with the reflection questions one at a time — don't rush. Pray briefly together to close. Most sessions run twenty to forty minutes, and the Sunday gathering can run a little longer. Consistency matters far more than length or eloquence — a short worship time that happens faithfully will shape your family more deeply than any single grand event.

Practical Suggestions

Choose a regular time. After dinner works well for many families — everyone is already gathered. The same evening each week removes the friction of scheduling. Advent is a natural season to establish this rhythm before the new year.

Let the children participate. Give younger children the task of lighting a candle before worship begins. Let older children take turns reading Scripture aloud. Ask even the youngest children the discussion questions — their answers are often more honest and more theological than the adults expect.

Keep it sustainable. Guard the rhythm jealously, especially at the start. You can always go longer when the conversation takes you there; you cannot force length when attention is gone. A rhythm that endures is worth more than a grand session attempted twice a year.

Don't wait until you feel ready. There is no right preparation. Open the Bible, read the passage, ask the question, pray. The Holy Spirit is sufficient to work through imperfect fathers and mothers who are willing to try. Remember Timothy, who knew the Scriptures "*from childhood*" because his mother and grandmother first taught him at home (2 Timothy 3:14–15).

"As for me and my house, we will serve the Lord."

JOSHUA 24:15

The Four Elements

Historically, family worship has included four simple elements. You do not need all four every time, but each adds something:

Scripture Reading

Read the passage for the week aloud. For longer passages, divide the reading among family members.

Discussion

Ask one or two questions from the week's devotional. Let the conversation go where it goes.

Singing

A single verse of a Christmas hymn sung together is enough. O Come, O Come, Emmanuel is particularly fitting for Advent.

Prayer

Close with a brief prayer — thanksgiving, confession, a request. Let the oldest child or youngest adult lead sometimes.



FIRST WEEK OF ADVENT

I

The Tree

"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed."

1 PETER 2:24

Week One · First Week of Advent

Why a Tree?

Preparation This Week

The first Sunday of Advent — the fourth Sunday before Christmas — begins the four-week journey. Find a Christmas tree (a real one if you can) and set it up in your home. This week, the tree stands alone: no lights, no ornaments, no decorations. Leave it bare. That is the point. Gather your family around it for worship using the readings below.

*E*very December, families carry a tree into their homes and cover it with lights and ornaments. Most of us have done it for as long as we can remember. But have you ever stopped to ask: *Why a tree?*

It turns out the Bible has a lot to say about trees. In fact, the very first pages of the Bible and the very last pages of the Bible both centre on a tree. And the most important event in the middle of the Bible — the death of Jesus — happened on a tree. Trees are not just background scenery in God's story. They are at the heart of it.

"The Bible begins and ends with a tree — and the whole story of what God has done for us hangs between them."

How It All Began

At the very beginning of the Bible, God created a beautiful garden and placed the first man and woman — Adam and Eve — inside it. In the middle of that garden, God placed two special trees.

The first was called the Tree of Life. It represented the life God wanted to share with the people He had made — a life of closeness with Him that would never end. The second was called the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. God gave Adam and Eve one simple instruction: you may eat from any tree in the garden — every single one — except this one. It was a test of trust. Would they take God at His word?

They didn't. They ate from the one tree God had told them to leave alone. And everything broke. Their closeness with God was shattered. They were sent out of the garden. An angel with a flaming sword was set to guard the way back to the Tree of Life. The door was shut. Humanity was cut off from the life God had intended for them.

This is what the Bible calls "the fall" — the moment when sin entered the world. It is the reason the world is broken. It is the reason we feel, deep down, that something is not the way it is supposed to be. And it all happened at a tree.

God Keeps Coming Back to Trees

After the fall, trees keep showing up throughout the Bible — always pointing to something important.

The book of Psalms describes a person who trusts God as being like "a tree planted by streams of water" (Psalm 1:3) – alive, fruitful, deeply rooted. It is a picture of the life God still wants for us, even after everything went wrong. The prophets – the men God sent to speak His messages to the people of Israel – call God's people "oaks of righteousness" (Isaiah 61:3), meaning people whose lives are strong, upright, and planted by God Himself.

But there is also a darker thread. In the Law – the rules God gave to Moses for the people of Israel – there is a striking statement: "*Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree*" (Deuteronomy 21:23). In that time, being hung on a tree after death was the most shameful punishment imaginable. It meant you were under God's judgement. It was a sign that you had been completely rejected.

Hold that thought. It becomes the most important thing in the story.

The Tree at the Centre of History

Hundreds of years later, Jesus of Nazareth – the Son of God – was executed by the Roman government on a wooden cross. The early Christians never forgot what that cross was made of. When the apostle Peter stood before the rulers of Israel after Jesus' resurrection, he said it bluntly: "*You killed him by hanging him on a tree*" (Acts 5:30).

Why did Peter use that word — *tree*? Because he wanted everyone to see the connection. The curse that was pronounced in the Law — "cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree" — landed on Jesus. Not because Jesus deserved it. He was the only person who ever lived a perfect life. But He chose to take that curse on Himself, so that it would no longer fall on us.

The apostle Paul explained it this way: Jesus "*redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us*" (Galatians 3:13). He took the punishment that our sin deserved, bearing it in His own body, on the tree (1 Peter 2:24). And because He did, the way back to God — the way that was blocked when Adam and Eve were sent out of the garden — is open again.

What was lost at one tree was won back at another.

The Tree at the End of the Story

The Bible does not end at the cross. In the very last chapter of the Bible — the book of Revelation — there is a vision of the world as God always intended it to be. A river of life flows from the throne of God. And standing beside that river is the Tree of Life.

The same tree that was guarded by an angel with a flaming sword at the beginning of the story is now open to everyone. No angel. No sword. No barrier. It bears twelve kinds of fruit — one for every month — and its leaves are described as being "for the healing of the nations" (Revelation 22:2). Everything that was broken in the garden is healed. Everything that was lost is restored. The story that began with a tree ends with a tree.

Your Tree Tells This Story

The Christmas tree standing bare in your living room is not a meaningless decoration. It is an opportunity – a chance to tell your family the oldest and most important story in the world. The story of how we were made for closeness with God, how that closeness was broken, and how God Himself came to restore it – all centred on a tree.

This week, as you look at the bare tree, let it speak. It stands stripped and unadorned, with nothing to cover it or make it pretty. That is exactly how the cross stood. And that is the point. Before the lights, before the ornaments, before the gifts – there is just the tree. Just the story of what God has done.

Study Guide

Four sessions for the family — one for the Sunday gathering, three for the days of the week. Each session ends with reflection questions. Times are guides, not timers.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~25 MIN

The Two Trees in Eden

Begin Advent at the beginning. Set up the bare tree, then sit beside it and read where the whole story of trees starts: in a garden, with a choice.

A Garden With Two Trees

Genesis 2:4-17

God plants a garden and places two trees at its center — the Tree of Life and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil.

REFLECT

1. Why do you think God placed both trees in the garden, and not just the Tree of Life? What does that tell you about the kind of relationship God wanted with Adam and Eve?
2. God's instruction was generous — eat from *any* tree, except one. How does Scripture's picture of a single restraint inside enormous freedom compare with how we usually think of God's commands?

The Choice and Its Cost

Genesis 3:1-24

The serpent, the forbidden tree, the fall, and exile from the Tree of Life — the garden gate is closed, the way back guarded by an angel with a flaming sword.

REFLECT

1. The serpent's first move was to make Eve question God's word: "Did God actually say...?" Where do you feel that same question pressed on you in your own life right now?
2. Adam and Eve are not struck down — they are *sent out*, and the way back to the Tree of Life is barred. Why does the Bible describe the consequence of sin as exile rather than only punishment?
3. Look at the bare tree in your living room. It stands stripped, unadorned — much like Adam and Eve at the end of Genesis 3, stripped of glory and sent into the cold. How does the bare tree help you feel the ache that the rest of the Bible answers?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the story of the tree does not end in Genesis 3.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

The Tree as a Picture of Life

After Eden, trees keep showing up — sometimes as a picture of the flourishing life God wants to give His people, sometimes as a warning about the trees that grow tall on their own pride.

Rooted by the Water

Psalm 1:1-6

The righteous are like a tree planted by streams of water — flourishing because of where they are rooted, not because of effort.

Proverbs 3:13-20

Wisdom "is a tree of life to those who lay hold of her" — blessing flows from fearing the Lord.

Proverbs 11:28-31

"The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life" — the one who wins souls is wise.

REFLECT

1. A tree planted by water did not choose its place — it was planted there. What does this teach us about how a flourishing life with God begins?
2. Proverbs calls wisdom itself a "tree of life." If the tree of life in Eden was lost, what does it mean that wisdom is now offered as a kind of restoration?
3. If your life were a tree, what fruit would the people closest to you say they have tasted from it this past year?

Two Destinies, One Choice

Jeremiah 17:5-10

Two destinies contrasted — the one who trusts in self is like a shrub in the desert; the one who trusts the Lord is like a tree planted by water.

Ezekiel 17:22-24

God Himself plants a tender sprig on a high mountain — a quiet promise that the Messiah will grow from a line that looks broken.

REFLECT

1. Jeremiah's contrast is not righteous-versus-wicked but trusting-in-God versus trusting-in-self. Where in your week is your trust currently planted?
2. Ezekiel says God will personally take a tender sprig and plant it. Why does the Bible keep returning to the picture of God as the gardener — and what comfort is in that?

Trees of Pride, Cut Down

Daniel 4:10-26

Nebuchadnezzar's dream of the great tree cut down — God humbles the proud.

Zechariah 11:1-6

The cedars and oaks fall — judgment sweeps through the proud trees of the nations.

REFLECT

1. Daniel and Zechariah both show God cutting down trees that grew tall on their own strength. What is the difference between a tree God plants (Jeremiah, Ezekiel) and a tree that grows itself (Daniel, Zechariah)?
2. Where in your own life have you noticed God gently lopping off something that was growing on its own pride?

Close in prayer. Ask God to plant your family deeper in Him this week.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~25 MIN

The Tree of the Curse, the Tree of the Cross

A startling thread runs through Scripture: the curse falls on a tree — and the rescue comes through a tree. This is the heart of why Christians have always seen the cross when they look at a tree.

A Curse Spoken Centuries Early

Deuteronomy 21:22-23

"A hanged man is cursed by God" — the law that would one day point to Calvary.

REFLECT

1. Why did God put this specific verse in the Law a thousand years before Jesus? What is He preparing His people to recognize?

"You Killed Him by Hanging Him on a Tree"

Acts 5:27-33

Peter before the Sanhedrin — "the God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree."

Acts 10:34-43

Peter to Cornelius — "they put him to death by hanging him on a tree" — and the promise of forgiveness through His name.

REFLECT

1. The apostles could have said "cross." They keep saying *tree*. What connection are they trying to make in their hearers' minds?
2. In Acts 10, the message of the tree goes for the first time to a Gentile household. Why is it good news that the curse-bearing tree is announced not just to Israel but to "every nation"?

The Great Exchange

Galatians 3:10-14

"Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree" — Christ bears the curse so that the blessing of Abraham might come to us.

1 Peter 2:21-25

"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree" — the Shepherd who brings us home.

REFLECT

1. Paul says Jesus became a curse for us. What is the difference between Jesus being treated unjustly and Jesus being deliberately treated as cursed in our place?
2. Peter says we were healed by His wounds. Where in your life — fears, regrets, broken places — do you most need that healing this Advent?
3. The Tree of Knowledge brought a curse no one could lift. The cross — another tree — lifts the curse from anyone who will look to it. How does this reframe the bare tree in your living room?

Close in prayer. Thank Jesus for hanging on a tree so that we would not have to.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Fruit, Restoration, and the Tree of Life

The story of trees runs all the way to Revelation, where the very tree that was barred at the beginning is open again to anyone who will come.

Beauty for Ashes

Isaiah 61:1-6

God's people will be called "oaks of righteousness, a planting of the Lord" — beauty for ashes.

REFLECT

1. God promises to call His people "oaks of righteousness, a planting of the Lord." What does it mean that the strength of an oak is something God gives, not something we grow?
2. "Beauty for ashes" — what part of your family's story this Advent feels like ashes that you would like to place into God's hands?

By Their Fruit You Will Know Them

Matthew 7:15-23

"Every good tree bears good fruit" — you will recognize them by their fruit.

Matthew 12:33-37

"Either make the tree good and its fruit good, or make the tree bad" — the heart revealed.

Luke 13:6-9

The parable of the barren fig tree — patience, judgment, and one more year of grace.

John 15:1-8

"I am the vine, you are the branches" — abiding in Christ, the living wood.

REFLECT

1. Jesus is relentless about fruit. Why is fruit the test, and not effort, sincerity, or appearance?
2. The barren fig tree gets one more year. How does the patience of God in that parable shape your view of someone in your life who has not yet come to faith?
3. John 15 says the secret of fruit is *abiding*, not striving. What does that look like for you in this season?

The Tree of Life, Open Again

Revelation 2:1-7

"To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life" — the promise renewed.

Revelation 22:1-5

The Tree of Life restored, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, its leaves for the healing of the nations.

REFLECT

1. The tree barred by an angel in Genesis 3 stands wide open in Revelation 22. What happened in between to take the angel away?
2. The leaves of the tree are "for the healing of the nations." What does it mean that the end of the Bible's story is not just personal salvation, but the healing of whole peoples?
3. Look once more at the bare tree in your home. The story that began at a tree in Eden, ran through a tree at Calvary, ends at a tree in the new creation. How will you tell that story to your family this week?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the story of the tree ends with healing, not exile.



SECOND WEEK OF ADVENT

II

The Light

"But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin."

1 JOHN 1:7

Week Two · Second Week of Advent

Do You See the Lights?

Preparation This Week

On the second Sunday of Advent, hang lights on your bare tree — white or clear lights are especially meaningful, though any colour works. Do not add ornaments yet. Let the lit tree stand alone for the week: tree and light, nothing more. The lights themselves are the message.

*T*hink about how most families decorate their tree. The lights go on first — and then, within minutes, they disappear under layers of ornaments, tinsel, and ribbon. We step back and admire the finished product, but the lights themselves are buried. They are still there, glowing behind everything else, but no one is looking at them anymore.

It is a small parable. Many of us treat the light of God in our lives the same way. We pile on activity, entertainment, comfort, ambition — even good things, important things — until the light that was supposed to be the foundation of everything becomes invisible. Not extinguished. Just covered. We have stopped seeing it.

This week, your tree will not let you do that. There are no ornaments to hide behind. There is only the bare tree from last week — and now, light. Look at it. Sit with your family in a darkened room and let the tree glow. What you are seeing is a picture of the gospel.

*"God said, 'Let there be light' — and there was light.
Before the sun. Before the stars. Before anything else
existed. Light came first."*

Light Before All Things

When God created the universe, the very first thing He made was light (Genesis 1:3). Not the sun — that came on the fourth day. Not the stars or the moon. Light itself, called into existence by the voice of God, preceding and undergirding everything that would follow. This is not a scientific puzzle to be solved. It is a theological declaration: God is the source of all light. He does not depend on anything He has made. He is the light, and *"in him is no darkness at all"* (1 John 1:5).

But darkness is real. The Bible does not pretend otherwise. Job sat in ashes and cursed the day he was born, longing for a darkness so complete that not even God would look for him (Job 3). The psalmist cried out from the pit, *"Darkness is my closest friend"* (Psalm 88:18). The people of Israel walked in literal darkness during the exile — centuries of silence, oppression, and waiting. Darkness is what the world looks like when the light is hidden.

Into that darkness, the prophets spoke. Isaiah declared, *"The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light"* (Isaiah 9:2). He promised that God would send His servant as *"a light for the nations, to open the eyes that are blind"* (Isaiah 42:6-7). And Malachi, the last prophetic voice before four hundred years of silence, ended with a promise: *"The sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings"* (Malachi 4:2).

Then the silence fell. Four centuries. No prophet. No word. No sign. And then — a baby, born at night, in a stable, in an occupied backwater of the Roman Empire. Angels appeared to shepherds in the dark, and *"the glory of the Lord shone around them"* (Luke 2:9). The light had come. Not as the world expected. Not with armies or spectacle. But as a child, wrapped in cloths, laid in a feeding trough.

John's Gospel opens not with the manger but with the meaning behind it: *"In him was life, and the life was the light of men. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it"* (John 1:4-5). This is the claim of Christmas. The light is not a metaphor. It is a person. And the darkness — all of it, every kind, from Eden's exile to your worst night — has not overcome it.

Your Tree in the Darkness

The lights on your tree this week are not decorations. They are a confession. They say: we believe that the light has come. We believe that the darkness does not win. We believe that the God who said "Let there be light" before anything else existed has sent His own Son as the true Light into the world — and that *"whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life"* (John 8:12).

But the Bible is honest about light in a way that should unsettle us. Jesus said, "*The light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light*" (John 3:19). The light is here. The question is whether we will step into it — or whether we prefer the comfort of the dark. Walking in the light means walking in truth, in confession, in fellowship (1 John 1:7). It means being seen. That is harder than it sounds.

Study Guide

Four sessions for the family — one for the Sunday gathering, three for the days of the week. Each session ends with reflection questions.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~20 MIN

Light Before All Else

Hang the lights, then sit in the glow with the room dark and read where the Bible's whole story of light begins — before there was a sun, a moon, or a single star.

"Let There Be Light"

Genesis 1:1-5

God's first act of creation — light called into existence by His voice, before the sun, moon, or stars exist.

Genesis 1:14-19

God creates the sun, moon, and stars on the fourth day — the lights of the sky serve a Light that was already there.

REFLECT

1. The first thing God made was not a star or a sun, but light itself. What is the Bible telling us about God when it makes light come *before* the things that produce it?
2. Light is the only thing God called "good" before there was anyone to see it. Why does that matter when you feel like no one is watching the small good things you are doing?
3. Look at the lights on your tree. Before any ornament, any gift, any other thing of Christmas — there is just light. How does that match the way the Bible begins?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the same God who first said "let there be light" still speaks light into our darkness.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

Darkness and the Cry for Light

The Bible is honest about darkness — plagues, laments, and dark nights of the soul. Before we read the promise of light, we sit with the people who longed for it.

When Darkness Falls

Exodus 10:21-29

The plague of darkness over Egypt — three days so thick it could be felt, yet Israel had light in their dwellings.

Job 3:1-26

Job laments in darkness — a man who has lost everything and wishes the day of his birth had been swallowed by night.

Psalms 88

"Darkness is my closest friend" — the Bible's darkest psalm, a cry from someone who sees no light at all.

REFLECT

1. God did not edit the darkness out of the Bible — He kept Job and Psalm 88 in. Why is it important that Scripture has space for the people who feel no light?
2. In Egypt, Israel had light in their homes while darkness covered the land. What does it mean that God can keep light burning in a household even while everything around it is dark?

A Prayer for Illumination

Psalm 27:1-6

"The Lord is my light and my salvation — whom shall I fear?"

Psalm 36:5-9

"In your light do we see light" — all true seeing depends on God's illumination.

Psalm 43:1-5

"Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me" — a prayer for God's light to guide the way home.

Psalm 119:105-112

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" — Scripture as the light we walk by.

REFLECT

1. David calls the Lord his light, his salvation, and his stronghold all in one verse. What is the difference between calling God your light and merely calling Him helpful?
2. Psalm 119 says God's word is a lamp to your feet — enough light for the next step, not the next mile. Where is God currently giving you only enough light for the next step?

Close in prayer. Pray for someone in your life who is sitting in a darkness like Job's or Psalm 88.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~35 MIN

The Light Promised, the Light Arrives

For centuries the prophets promised dawn was coming. Then four hundred years of silence — and then a baby, born at night, in a stable.

The Promise of Dawn

Isaiah 9:1-7

"The people walking in darkness have seen a great light" — the promised Prince of Peace.

Isaiah 42:5-9

"I will give you as a light for the nations, to open the eyes that are blind" — the Servant's mission.

Isaiah 60:1-5

"Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the Lord has risen upon you."

Malachi 4:1-6

"The sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings" — the last promise before four centuries of silence.

REFLECT

1. Isaiah promised "a great light" to people walking in darkness. Note that he says *walking*, not standing still. What does it look like to keep walking when you cannot see what's ahead?
2. Malachi was the last word from God for four hundred years. What might it have been like to be a faithful Israelite in that long silence — and what comfort do you draw from knowing God was not absent in it?

The Light in the Manger

John 1:1-18

"In him was life, and the life was the light of men. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it."

Luke 2:1-21

The birth of Jesus — the light enters the world at night, in poverty, announced to shepherds by the glory of the Lord.

REFLECT

1. John says the light shines in the darkness and the darkness *has not overcome it*. Where in your life right now do you most need to hear that the darkness has not won?
2. God announced the arrival of His Son to night-shift shepherds — not to kings or priests. What is God saying about who He is by the people He chooses to tell first?
3. Sit quietly with only your tree lights on. Read John 1:1–5 again, slowly. What do those familiar words sound like in the dark?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He did not leave us in the dark.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

The Light Embraced — and the Eternal Day

The Light has come — but a light demands a response. We close this week looking at *what it means to walk in the light, and at the city where God Himself will be the light forever.*

The Light You Cannot Stay Neutral About

John 8:12–20

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

John 3:19–21

"The light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light" — why some turn away.

REFLECT

1. Jesus does not say "I will show you light." He says, "I *am* the light." What is the difference between trying to find light and following the One who is light?
2. John 3 says some loved darkness because their deeds were evil. Where in your life do you find yourself preferring not to be seen — and what is the gospel's invitation to bring it into the light?

Walking as Children of Light

Matthew 5:14–16

"You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden" — Jesus tells His followers they carry the light.

Ephesians 5:8–14

"You were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light."

1 John 1:5–10

"God is light, and in him is no darkness at all" — walking in the light means walking in truth and fellowship.

REFLECT

1. Jesus says "you are the light of the world" — present tense, before they had done anything. What does that change about how you understand your role at home, at work, or at school?
2. 1 John says walking in the light means honest fellowship and confession, not flawlessness. What hidden thing might it be time to bring into the light this Advent?

No More Night

Revelation 21:22-27

"The city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light" — the new Jerusalem.

Revelation 22:1-5

"Night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light" — the story ends where it began.

REFLECT

1. The Bible begins with God saying "let there be light" and ends with God Himself *being* the light. What is gained by reading those two scenes together?
2. "Night will be no more." If you took that promise seriously this week, what fear or grief would loosen its grip on you?
3. Look once more at the tree, lit and bare, no ornaments yet. The lights point to the Light. How will you keep seeing the lights — really seeing them — when the ornaments go on next week?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the day that is coming when the lights on the tree will no longer be needed.

THIRD WEEK OF ADVENT

III

Prophecy & Heritage

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31



Week Three · Third Week of Advent

The Forgotten Ornaments

Preparation This Week

On the third Sunday of Advent, decorate your lit tree together. Hang the pretty ornaments and the meaningful ones alike. But when you come to the ones that carry a story — heirlooms, symbols of faith, tokens of God's faithfulness in your family — pause and **tell that story aloud**. What does it represent? Who gave it? What has God done? Each year, add more meaningful ornaments. **Leave the very top of the tree bare** — that moment belongs to next week.

*E*very family has a box of Christmas ornaments. Most of them have been hanging on trees for years — some for decades. But ask anyone what a particular ornament means, where it came from, or why it matters, and you will usually get a shrug. The stories have been lost. The ornaments still come out every December, but they have become weightless — familiar objects with forgotten meanings.

The Bible warns that faith can go the same way. Children can grow up hearing the stories of Scripture — handling them, feeling their familiar weight, even placing them in the right order — without ever grasping the story behind the story. They know that Jesus was born in Bethlehem. But do they know that the prophet Micah named that town seven hundred years before it happened (Micah 5:2)? They know

that Jesus died on a cross. But do they know that David described the crucifixion in Psalm 22 a thousand years before crucifixion was invented? They know the nativity. But do they know why it matters — to them, here, now?

This is why God has always commanded His people to do two things: *remember* and *pass it on*.

"Prophecy is memory made certain in advance. Every ornament on the tree of faith was placed there by the hand of God — centuries before Christmas morning."

Stones, Feasts, and Stories

When Israel crossed the Jordan into the Promised Land, God told Joshua to take twelve stones from the riverbed and pile them on the bank. Why? *"When your children ask, 'What do these stones mean?' — tell them"* (Joshua 4:6-7). The stones had no value in themselves. Their purpose was to provoke a question, so that the answer — God's faithfulness — would be spoken aloud to the next generation.

The Passover served the same purpose. God built the question into the ceremony itself: *"When your children say to you, 'What do you mean by this service?' — you shall say, 'It is the sacrifice of the Lord's Passover'"* (Exodus 12:26-27). Every year, the family was to retell the story of deliverance from Egypt. Moses charged the people directly: *"Teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down,*

and when you rise" (Deuteronomy 6:7). The faith was not meant to be stored in a chest and brought out once a year. It was meant to be spoken — constantly, naturally, in the rhythm of daily life.

And running alongside this thread of remembrance is the thread of prophecy. God did not only tell His people what He had done. He told them what He was going to do — with a precision that still astonishes. The offspring of the woman would crush the serpent's head (Genesis 3:15). The blessing would come through Abraham's line (Genesis 12:3). The king would sit on David's throne forever (2 Samuel 7:13). A virgin would conceive (Isaiah 7:14). The ruler would come from Bethlehem (Micah 5:2). The servant would be pierced for our transgressions (Isaiah 53:5). Century after century, the picture sharpened until there was only one face it could be.

When Prophecy Became a Person

One Sabbath in Nazareth, Jesus stood up in the synagogue, unrolled the scroll of Isaiah, and read: *"The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor"* (Luke 4:18, quoting Isaiah 61:1). He rolled the scroll back up, sat down, and said seven words that changed everything: *"Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing"* (Luke 4:21).

The people who had known Him since childhood were furious. They tried to throw Him off a cliff (Luke 4:28–29). This is the strange danger of familiarity — the same danger that turns meaningful ornaments into forgotten decorations. The prophecies were right in front of them, being fulfilled before their eyes, and they could not see it.

After the resurrection, on the road to Emmaus, Jesus walked two disciples through the entire Old Testament — Moses, the Prophets, the Psalms — and showed them that *every thread led to Him* (Luke 24:27). Their hearts burned within them (Luke 24:32). They had read these Scriptures their whole lives. But they had never seen the story behind the story.

Your Tree as a Memorial

As you hang ornaments on the tree, you are doing what Joshua did with his stones — at least with some of them. Not every ornament needs to carry weight. Many are simply pretty, and that is fine. But scattered among them are the ones that do carry a story: a grandparent's ornament and the weight of generational faith; a wooden cross and the whole gospel; an ornament made by a child's hands. Those are the memorial stones.

With those, resist the temptation to rush. Hang each one slowly. Speak its meaning aloud. Ask the children what they think it represents. Each year, add more — an answered prayer, a milestone, a season of grace. Over time, the tree itself becomes a map of your family's walk with God.

And as the tree fills up, notice what is missing. The top is bare. The tree is not complete yet. The greatest gift has not arrived. That is the tension of Advent — the ache of waiting that makes Christmas morning what it is.

Study Guide

Four sessions for the family — one for the Sunday gathering, three for the days of the week. Each session ends with reflection questions.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~35 MIN

The Command to Remember

As you hang each ornament, you are doing what God's people have always done — building a memorial that provokes a question, so that the answer can be told.

Stones, Feasts, and Stories

Genesis 28:10-22

Jacob's ladder — he sets up a stone as a memorial and says, "Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it."

Exodus 12:1-14

The Passover instituted — "This day shall be for you a memorial day... throughout your generations."

Joshua 4:1-9

Twelve stones from the Jordan — "When your children ask, 'What do these stones mean?' — tell them..."

REFLECT

1. God could have written His acts on the sky for all to see. Instead He told His people to pile up stones, eat a meal, and explain it to their children. Why does He insist that remembering happen at the family table?
2. Jacob said, "Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it." Where in your family's recent story did God meet you that you only saw afterward?

Pass It On

Deuteronomy 4:1-15

"Make them known to your children and your children's children" — Moses' charge to Israel before they enter the land.

Deuteronomy 6:4-9

"Teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house" — the Shema.

REFLECT

1. The Shema says to talk of God's words "when you sit, when you walk, when you lie down, when you rise." This is not a programme — it's a rhythm. Where in your family's daily rhythm could God's story more naturally find a voice?
2. Look at the ornaments going on the tree. Pick one with a story behind it and tell that story now. Why is that small act of telling a kind of obedience?

Close in prayer. Ask God to make your home a place where His story is constantly retold.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Prophecy Spoken — The Promise Takes Shape

From a single line in Eden to a king on David's throne, God's promise of a Rescuer narrows step by step over hundreds of years.

A Promise From the Beginning

Genesis 3:15

The first prophecy — the offspring of the woman will crush the serpent's head. The rescue is promised before the exile begins.

Genesis 12:1-3

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed" — God's covenant with Abraham narrows the promise to one line.

2 Samuel 7:12-16

"Your throne shall be established forever" — God promises David a kingdom that will never end.

REFLECT

1. Before the gates of Eden close, God already promises a Rescuer. What does this tell you about the timing of God's grace toward you when you have failed?
2. Watch the promise narrow: from "the offspring of the woman" (everyone), to "Abraham's family" (one nation), to "David's throne" (one royal line). Why does God reveal the gospel slowly across generations rather than all at once?

The Picture Sharpens

Isaiah 7:14

"The virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" — God with us.

Isaiah 11:1-10

"A shoot from the stump of Jesse" — when the royal line looks dead, a branch will grow.

REFLECT

1. "Immanuel" means "God with us." Why is "with-ness" — not rescue, not strength, not provision — the heart of God's promise?
2. Isaiah pictures David's line as a stump — cut down, finished. And then a shoot grows from it. Where in your family's life does something feel like a stump you have written off, that God may yet grow something out of?

Down to the Detail

Micah 5:1-5

"But you, O Bethlehem... from you shall come forth one who is to be ruler in Israel" — the town named centuries beforehand.

Isaiah 53

The Suffering Servant — "He was pierced for our transgressions, crushed for our iniquities." Written 700 years before Calvary.

REFLECT

1. Micah names Bethlehem 700 years before Jesus is born there. Why does God so often build in details that can only be appreciated in hindsight?
2. Isaiah 53 describes the cross long before there was a cross — the piercing, the crushing, the silence, the burial with the rich. As you read it aloud, what part of the description lands hardest for you?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He keeps promises across centuries — and across generations.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

The Cross Foretold — and "Today Fulfilled"

The picture sharpens to its most unmistakable point: the cross itself, described centuries before it happened — and the Sunday in Nazareth when Jesus rolled up the scroll and said, "Today this Scripture is fulfilled."

The Cross, Foretold

Zechariah 12:10-13:9

"They shall look on me, on him whom they have pierced, and they shall mourn" — a prophecy of the cross and of repentance.

Psalms 22:1-18

"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" — David writes the words Jesus will speak from the cross, a thousand years early.

REFLECT

1. Zechariah pictures God's people one day "looking on Him whom they have pierced" — and mourning. What does it mean to grieve over what our sin cost Him, even now?
2. David wrote Psalm 22 long before crucifixion existed. Read it again, slowly. What does it do to your view of Scripture that the prayer of a dying king matched, line by line, the prayer of a dying Saviour?

"Today This Scripture Is Fulfilled"

Matthew 1:18-25

"All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet" — Matthew shows how Jesus' birth fulfills Isaiah.

Luke 4:14-30

Jesus reads from Isaiah in the synagogue and declares: "Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing."

Luke 24:25-27

On the road to Emmaus, the risen Jesus opens all the Scriptures and shows how everything pointed to Him.

John 20:30-31

"These are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life."

REFLECT

1. The people of Nazareth had known Jesus since childhood. They knew the prophecies. They were furious when He said the prophecies pointed to Him. Why does familiarity sometimes make it harder to see what God is doing?
2. On the Emmaus road, two grieving disciples needed Jesus to walk them through the whole Old Testament before they could see Him. Where in your own life do you need God to slow down and walk you through the story again?
3. John says "these are written so that you may believe." The whole point of the gospels is not information — it is faith. What is one place this Advent where you are being asked to move from knowing about Jesus to trusting Him?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He keeps every promise.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Forgetting, and the Heritage That Endures

Memory is fragile. Faith can be lost in a single generation if it isn't passed on. We end the week with the warnings — and the picture of a heritage that reaches every nation on earth.

When the Story Stops Being Told

Judges 2:6-15

"There arose another generation after them who did not know the Lord" — what happens when the story is not passed on.

Hebrews 2:1-4

"We must pay much closer attention to what we have heard, lest we drift away from it."

Revelation 3:14-22

"You are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold" — the church that thought it had everything but had lost its fire.

REFLECT

1. Judges says a generation arose that "did not know the Lord." It only took one. What part of the story most needs to be deliberately told to the children at your table this season?
2. Hebrews warns that we don't usually *reject* the gospel — we *drift* from it. What are the small drifts you can already see in your own walk this year?
3. Laodicea was a wealthy church that thought it lacked nothing. Where does comfort, in your home, threaten to dull your hunger for God?

A Faith That Outlives Us

Psalm 78:1-8

"We will tell the coming generation the glorious deeds of the Lord" — so that they would set their hope in God.

2 Timothy 1:3-7

Paul remembers Timothy's faith — "a faith that dwelt first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice."

Isaiah 60:1-5

"Arise, shine, for your light has come" — the glory of the Lord rises over His people and draws the nations.

Revelation 5:9-10

"You ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" — the heritage reaches every family on earth.

REFLECT

1. Paul thanks God for a faith that came down to Timothy through his grandmother and mother. Who are the Lois and Eunice figures in your family – the ones whose faith you stand on?
2. Revelation 5 says the song of the redeemed includes every tribe, language, and nation. How does that picture stretch your sense of what kind of "heritage" your family is being grafted into?
3. Look at the tree, full of ornaments now. The top is still bare. What is missing – and what does it mean that the most important thing is still to come?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the people who passed the faith to you. Ask Him to make your family a faithful link in the chain.



CHRISTMAS WEEK

IV

The Gift & the Prize

"For by him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible... all things were created by him and for him."

COLOSSIANS 1:16



Week Four · Christmas Week

Look at Your Tree

Preparation This Week

On the fourth Sunday of Advent, place something meaningful at the very top of the tree — ideally a cross. A star or an angel may also be used, but a cross makes the theology explicit. Surround the tree with your gifts. Then on Christmas morning, **gather your family for worship before opening any presents** — read Scripture, sing a hymn, and pray together.

Step back and look at what has been built over the last four weeks.

In the first week, you brought a bare tree into your home and left it standing alone — stripped and unadorned, like the cross it was always pointing to. You read how God has been telling His story through trees from the very beginning: the Tree of Life in Eden, the tree of the curse, the tree at Calvary, the tree restored in the city of God.

In the second week, you hung lights on the bare branches and sat in the glow. You traced the thread of light through the whole Bible — from God's first creative act, through the darkness of exile and lament, through the prophets' promise that dawn was coming, to the night when the true Light entered the world as a baby.

In the third week, you hung ornaments — each one a memorial, a stone of remembrance. You told the stories. You traced the thread of prophecy from a vague promise in a garden to a specific baby in a specific town, and you saw how every detail was fulfilled.

Now, in the fourth week, the tree is complete. A cross sits at the top. Gifts are gathered beneath. And the question that has been building all Advent long finally arrives: *What is the gift — and will you receive it?*

"Every gift under the tree points to a gift that cannot be wrapped. Every light on the tree points to a Light that cannot be extinguished. The tree itself points to the cross — and the cross points to an empty tomb."

The Gift You Cannot Earn

The Bible is relentlessly clear about this: salvation is a gift. You cannot earn it, purchase it, or achieve it. Paul wrote it as plainly as words allow: *"The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord"* (Romans 6:23). And again: *"By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God"* (Ephesians 2:8).

This is what makes Christmas different from every other holiday. It is not a celebration of something humanity accomplished. It is a celebration of something God gave — at unimaginable cost to Himself. Paul described it this way: though

Jesus was in the form of God, He did not grasp at equality with God, but *"emptied himself,"* taking the form of a servant, being born in human likeness. He humbled Himself to the point of death — death on a cross (Philippians 2:6–8). Death on a tree.

The baby in the manger is the Creator of the universe. The one wrapped in cloths is the one who holds all things together. Colossians says it directly: *"By him all things were created, in heaven and on earth... all things were created through him and for him"* (Colossians 1:16). The gift is not merely a good teacher or a moral example. The gift is God Himself, entering His own creation, taking on the frailty and suffering of the world He made, in order to rescue the people He loves.

The Question Christmas Asks

But a gift must be received. And this is where Christmas becomes personal.

John wrote, *"Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life"* (1 John 5:12). There is no middle ground. The gift is offered freely, but it demands a response. You can admire it from a distance. You can appreciate the story. You can enjoy the season. But none of that is the same as receiving the gift.

Look at the people in the Christmas story. Mary said yes — though it would cost her everything she had planned (Luke 1:38). The shepherds left their flocks in the middle of the night and went immediately (Luke 2:15–16). The Magi travelled for months, following a star, bringing their best (Matthew

2:11). Simeon, who had waited his entire life, held the baby in his arms and said, "Now you are letting your servant depart in peace" (Luke 2:29). Each of them received the gift. Each of them was changed by it.

And then there were those who missed it entirely. Herod saw only a threat — and tried to kill the child. The religious leaders knew the prophecies by heart — they could quote Micah, they could point to Bethlehem (Matthew 2:5-6) — but they never walked the few miles to see for themselves. The gift was right in front of them, and they did not receive it.

Before You Open the Presents

On Christmas morning, before the wrapping paper flies, gather your family. Open the Word before you open the gifts. Read the story of Jesus' birth aloud (Luke 2:1-20) — let the youngest child who can read take a part. Sing one verse of a Christmas hymn together: *O Come, All Ye Faithful* or *Hark! The Herald Angels Sing*. Close with a prayer of thanksgiving. Then let the morning begin.

You will find, year after year, that this act of worship at the start of Christmas morning becomes one of the most treasured memories your family carries. It declares, once more, what the tree has been saying all along: the gift is not under the tree. The gift is on the tree — and He is risen.

Study Guide

Four sessions for the family — one for the Sunday gathering, three for the days of the week (the last is written for Christmas morning before the gifts are opened).

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~20 MIN

The Gift Promised

Place the cross at the top of the tree. The promise of a Rescuer was the very first gift God gave — pledged before the gates of Eden closed, foreshadowed in Abraham's son, and named by Isaiah long before there was a manger.

A Promise Before the Gate Closed

Genesis 3:15

The first promise — an offspring who will crush the serpent. The gift is pledged before the garden gate closes.

Genesis 22:1-18

Abraham offers Isaac — "God will provide for himself the lamb." A father's willingness foreshadows the Father's gift.

Isaiah 9:6-7

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given" — the gift described centuries before it arrives.

REFLECT

1. Genesis 3:15 is God's first response to human sin: a promise. Not a sentence, not a threat — a promise. What does it tell you about God that the rescue plan was already in His mouth before the door of Eden swung shut?
2. Abraham was asked to give up the son he loved. The Father did. What does that parallel say about the cost the gift carried for God Himself?
3. Look at the cross now sitting at the top of your tree. The whole story has been climbing toward this. What does it mean that the gift, in the end, looks like a cross?

Close in prayer. Thank the Father for not sparing His own Son, but giving Him up for us all.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~25 MIN

The Gift Anticipated

A short session. Three psalms and one prophet show how the people of God carried the promise across centuries — singing about a King they had never seen.

The King Promised in Song

Psalm 2

"You are my Son; today I have begotten you. Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage" — the Father's gift to the Son.

Psalm 110

"The Lord says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand" — David glimpses a King greater than himself.

Isaiah 11:1-10

"A shoot from the stump of Jesse" — the gift will come through a line that looks dead and finished.

Malachi 3:1-4

"The Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple" — the last prophetic voice before four centuries of silence.

REFLECT

1. David, Israel's greatest king, sings of a Lord greater than himself. What does it cost a leader to admit that the real King has not come yet?
2. Malachi promises the Lord will *suddenly* come — and then four hundred years of silence follow. What does it mean that "suddenly" in God's vocabulary may include a long, quiet wait?
3. Where in your own life are you currently waiting on a "sudden" answer that hasn't yet come?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the long, faithful patience of His people who waited centuries to see what we celebrate every December.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

The Gift Arrives

The Christmas story itself — Mary's yes, the manger, Simeon and Anna, the Magi. Read it slowly and let the children hear all of it.

The Arrival

Luke 1:26-56

The annunciation to Mary and her song of praise — "He has done great things for me, and holy is his name."

Luke 2:1-21

The birth of Jesus — the gift arrives in poverty and obscurity, wrapped in cloths, laid in a manger, announced to shepherds.

Luke 2:22-40

Simeon and Anna — two people who had waited their whole lives for this gift, and recognized it when it came.

Matthew 2

The Magi follow the star, bring gifts, and worship — outsiders travel farther than anyone to honor the King.

REFLECT

1. Mary's "yes" to God meant her plans, her reputation, even her safety would never be the same. What does her response teach you about what it costs to receive God's gift on His terms?
2. Simeon waited his whole life for one moment with Jesus, and counted it enough. Anna spent her widowhood in the temple, watching for Him. What might "waiting like Simeon and Anna" look like in your own ordinary days?
3. The shepherds were close and came running. The Magi were far and came after months of travel. The religious leaders were nearest of all and never came. Which of those three is closest to your heart's posture this Advent?

Close in prayer. Sit quietly with the wonder that God came as a baby.

SESSION 4 · CHRISTMAS MORNING ~50 MIN

The Gift Revealed and Received

A long final session — the climax of the four weeks. We open by asking who this baby actually was, then turn to the question every person must answer: will you receive the gift? If you can, save the last block for Christmas morning before the gifts are opened.

Who Is This Child?

John 1:1-18

"The Word became flesh and dwelt among us" — the eternal God enters His own creation as a baby.

Colossians 1:15-23

"He is the image of the invisible God... by him all things were created... and in him all things hold together."

Philippians 2:5-11

"Though he was in the form of God, he did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself" — the cost of the gift.

Hebrews 1:1-4

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature" — the final Word after all the prophets.

REFLECT

1. Colossians says *all things hold together in Him*. The baby in the manger is the one keeping the stars in their courses. How does this reframe what it means that He cried, slept, and needed to be fed?
2. Philippians says Jesus did not *grasp at equality* with God — He let it go for our sake. Where in your life are you grasping at something Jesus would let go of?
3. Hebrews says God spoke through prophets in many ways, but in these last days has spoken to us by His Son. If Jesus is God's final word, what specifically is God saying to your family through Him this Christmas?

The Free Gift

John 3:16–21

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son" — the gift and the choice it demands.

Romans 6:23

"The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."

2 Corinthians 9:15

"Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!"

1 John 5:1–12

"God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life" — the gift is a person.

REFLECT

1. A wage is something you earn. A gift is something you receive. Where in your relationship with God are you still trying to earn what He has already given?
2. 1 John says "the gift is a person." Christianity is not a programme to follow but a Person to receive. What does that change about how you would talk about your faith with someone who doesn't yet believe?

A Life Worthy of the Gift

Ephesians 2:8-10

"By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God" — you cannot earn it.

Ephesians 4:1-16

"Walk worthy of the calling to which you have been called" — because He has given us every gift, how then shall we live?

Romans 12:1-2

"Present your bodies as a living sacrifice" — the gift received becomes a life offered back.

REFLECT

1. Paul says we walk worthy of the calling *because* we've been given everything — not so that we will be. What is the difference between obedience that earns and obedience that thanks?
2. Romans 12 calls for a "living sacrifice" — a sacrifice that keeps walking off the altar. What part of your life this coming year would you most need to deliberately put back on the altar each morning?

The Prize Ahead – for Christmas Morning

Philippians 3:12-14

"I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus" – the gift is also a calling.

Revelation 21:1-7

"Behold, I am making all things new... the one who conquers will have this heritage" – the gift fully unwrapped at the end of all things.

Revelation 22:1-5

The Tree of Life, the river of life, the throne of God and of the Lamb – every thread of the story arrives here.

REFLECT

1. Look at the tree, fully decorated, cross at the top, gifts beneath. Walk through the four weeks aloud – the bare tree, the lights, the ornaments, the cross. What is the single sentence you most want your family to remember from this Advent?
2. The Tree of Life that was lost in Genesis stands open in Revelation 22. Every thread – the tree, the light, the prophecies, the gift – arrives at the same place. Why do you think God made the Bible end where it began?
3. If today were Christmas morning: before any wrapping paper is touched, name out loud one thing each person around the tree is most thankful to God for this year. Then open Luke 2 and read it aloud.

Close in prayer. Thank God for the inexpressible gift. Then – only then – open the others.



BACK MATTER

Further Resources

If you want to deepen your family worship practice beyond this Advent season, these resources are worth your time:

- Donald S. Whitney, *Family Worship* — A short, practical book on establishing and sustaining the habit. (Crossway)
- Joel R. Beeke, *Family Worship* — A brief, pastoral guide from the Dutch Reformed tradition; answers common objections and offers practical direction for getting started. (Reformation Heritage Books)
- *The New City Catechism* — Fifty-two questions and answers drawn from the Reformed confessional tradition, with a free web and mobile app including a children's mode. A natural companion to weekly family worship. (newcitycatechism.com)
- *The ESV Bible Online* — All Scripture readings in this devotional are taken from the English Standard Version. (esv.org)
- *Christmas Tree Devotional* — The companion website for this book, with the same content available freely online for sharing with friends and family. (christmastreedevotional.com)



About This Book



The Tree Tells a Story began as one family's attempt to answer a child's question: "Why do we put a tree inside our house?" The answer turned out to run from Genesis to Revelation.

This book is written for families — for parents who want to lead family worship through Advent without needing a seminary degree, and for grandparents, aunts and uncles, godparents, and friends who want to give a young family the gift of a tradition that grows richer every year.

An online edition of the same content, with linked Scripture passages and additional commentary, lives at christmastreedevotional.com.

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Soli Deo gloria.